

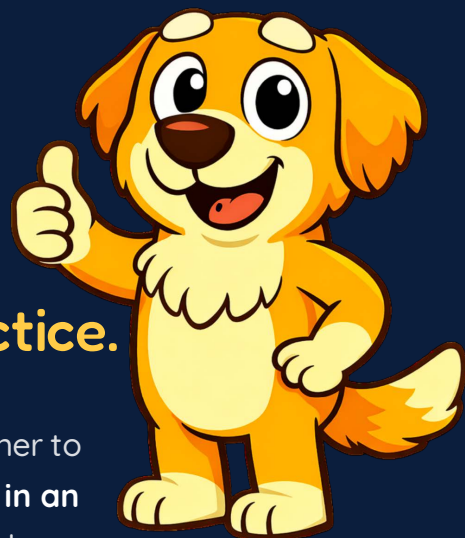
A FREE CLINICAL COMPANION · FOR FELLOW PRACTITIONERS

The Practitioner's Companion.

How the Decoder fits inside your practice.

A peer-to-peer document from one Behaviour Support Practitioner to others. **The clinical reasoning behind the resource, where it fits in an FBA workflow**, and three specific use-cases worth knowing about.

Designed to complement your practice, not replace it.



CREATED BY

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COMPANION TO

The Parent's Decoder · 8 pp
Does This Sound Like Me? · 8 pp
Both freely available

FROM ONE PRACTITIONER TO ANOTHER

Why I'm writing to you specifically.

This isn't a marketing document. It's a peer-to-peer note from a BSP working in regional NDIS who built a resource — and wants to share the clinical reasoning behind it with practitioners who might find it useful in their own work.

The Parent's Decoder and the companion worksheet (Does This Sound Like Me?) are **not designed to replace clinical assessment**. They're designed for the family-facing space *between* sessions — the place where most of the actual change happens, and where most parents have nothing to work with. If you're a BSP, OT, speech pathologist, child psychologist, school counsellor, or learning support teacher, you'll have noticed: parents leave a session with our recommendations and then face six days of real-life moments without us in the room.

*The decoder isn't a substitute for clinical work. It's a **scaffold for the parent** who has to do the work of regulation, repair, and connection in the moments we'll never see.*

If you decide to use these resources with the families on your caseload, I'd love that. If you decide they're not right for your practice, that's also useful information — and I'd genuinely value the feedback.

The next seven pages cover: the clinical reasoning behind each design choice, where the resources fit in an FBA-informed workflow, and three specific use-cases worth knowing about. *If any of it's useful for your practice, that's the whole point.*

THE REASONING BEHIND EACH DESIGN CHOICE

Why each section is built the way it is.

Every design choice in the Decoder + Worksheet pair was made deliberately. Here's the clinical reasoning, by section, in case it's useful for your own work or for evaluating whether the resource fits your practice.

DECODER · THE THREE-COLUMN STRUCTURE

Brain story · emotion underneath · road being built

The three columns map deliberately onto the **antecedent-behaviour-consequence sequence**, but reframed for parent comprehension. The "brain story" is the antecedent (neurological/sensory/cognitive load); the "emotion underneath" is the function (what the behaviour communicates); the "road being built" is the consequence pattern (what gets reinforced over time).

Parents don't need to know we're walking them through ABC. They just need the framework to *land naturally*.

WORKSHEET · THE THREE-OPTION RATING

Yes that's me · kind of · no not really

The "no, not really" option is non-negotiable. Without it, the worksheet becomes a **compliance instrument** — children select what they think the parent wants to hear. The legitimate "no" preserves the child's right to say *this framework doesn't fit me*, which is itself useful clinical data.

If a child marks "no, not really" across all five statements, that's diagnostic — not failure of the tool.

WORKSHEET · LISTENING-ONLY RULE

The grown-up's job is restraint, not interpretation

Parents trained in problem-solving will **over-interpret** their child's responses by default. The explicit "no fixing, no translating, no convincing" rule is borrowed from *nondirective play therapy principles* and from PBS's emphasis on stakeholder voice.

The page-2 framing front-loads this rule because it's the first thing that breaks under pressure during the activity.

WORKSHEET · FORWARD-ACTION COMMITMENT

One small thing each + check-back date

The closing page enforces **bidirectional commitment** — both child and parent name a specific behaviour change, and a date to revisit. This converts the worksheet from an exploratory tool into a *structured intervention with measurable outcomes*.

For BSPs running formal FBA: this can be filed as a parent-led behaviour support intervention with documented baseline.

THEORETICAL UNDERPINNINGS

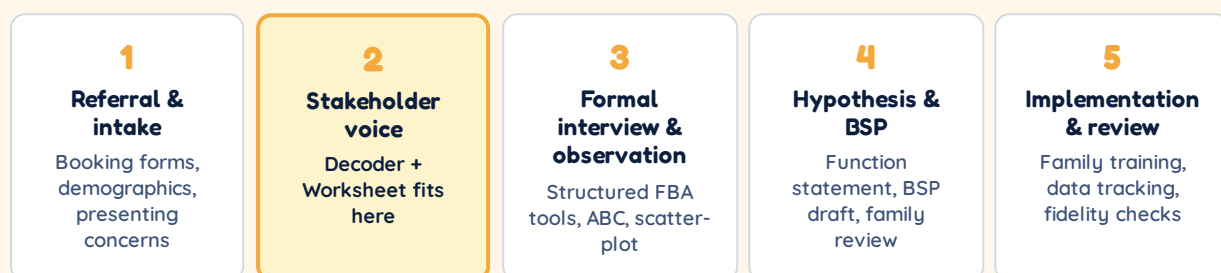
The brain-as-town metaphor draws on **polyvagal theory** (Porges) for the regulation layer, **self-determination theory** (Deci & Ryan) for the agency framing, and **Carol Dweck's growth mindset literature** for the road-building language. The PBS architecture — function-based formulation, stakeholder voice, skill-building over suppression — shapes the worksheet design throughout. *Nothing in the resource is therapy; everything in it is psychoeducation aligned to clinical principles.*

WHERE IT FITS IN AN FBA WORKFLOW

Inside the existing FBA pipeline.

For BSPs running standard FBA-informed practice, the resource fits cleanly into the assessment phase as a **stakeholder-voice instrument**. Specifically: it operates between intake and the formal interview, where most clinicians have a gap.

STANDARD FBA PIPELINE · 5 STAGES



Most FBA pipelines have a **silent gap between stages 1 and 3** — referral comes in, family waits 2–6 weeks for first formal session. In that gap, distress accumulates and the family arrives at the formal interview *already exhausted*. The Decoder + Worksheet pair is designed to fit that gap. It gives the family something to engage with structurally while waiting, and gives you a **warm assessment data point** from the child's voice before the first session.

PRACTITIONER-SPECIFIC USE · HOW I DO IT

In my own practice, I send the bundle as part of the *welcome pack* after intake is confirmed. The family completes the worksheet at home before our first session. I **review their responses 24 hours before the session** — the "what helps" tickbox in particular informs my opening question and reduces the amount of cold rapport-building required. By the time we start the formal FBA interview, I have a working hypothesis already; I'm just confirming it.

DOCUMENTATION NOTE · FOR NDIS-BILLED WORK

The completed worksheet is **filing-quality stakeholder voice documentation** — appropriate for inclusion in BSP files, NDIS audit documentation, and progress reports. The forward-commitment closing page (signed and dated) functions as a parent-led intervention plan, which can be referenced in subsequent sessions and reviewed at quarterly check-ins. *It does not replace formal BSP documentation — it supplements it.*

USE CASE 1 · PRE-SESSION HOMEWORK FOR NEW FAMILIES

SCENARIO

A new family enters your caseload. Wait time to first session is 2–4 weeks.

You've confirmed the intake. The family is anxious — they've been waiting for help, and the wait between booking and first session is exactly when distress is highest and engagement is lowest. By the time they arrive at session 1, half the family's emotional energy has gone to *getting through the wait*, not engaging with the clinical work.

The intervention: include the Decoder bundle in your welcome pack. Two PDFs, instructions to read the parent guide first, then complete the worksheet with the child *at any point in the next two weeks, no pressure to do it in any particular way*.

What you get out of it: the parent arrives at session 1 having already done the cognitive work of recognising patterns. The child arrives having had at least one structured conversation about what helps. You can open the session with: *"I read your worksheet — tell me about the moment you wrote 'school is too loud.'"* Rapport that would have taken 20 minutes is established in 60 seconds.

IMPLEMENTATION TIP

Don't make worksheet completion **mandatory before the first session**. Some families won't do it. That's also clinical data — families who don't engage with self-administered psychoeducation may need more scaffolding, or may have engagement barriers worth understanding before the formal FBA. *Treat non-completion as information, not as failure.*

WHAT YOU CAN DOCUMENT FROM THIS

Include the completed worksheet (or the family's choice not to complete it) in stakeholder-voice section of your FBA file. Reference specific tickbox responses in your BSP rationale. **If a child ticked "you saying yeah, that does feel unfair"** as a helpful response, that's antecedent-strategy data you can build into the BSP. Concrete, specific, child-sourced.

USE CASE 2 · BETWEEN-SESSION INTERVENTION FOR ESTABLISHED FAMILIES

SCENARIO

An existing family is mid-program. The parent is exhausted. The child has been escalating at home.

You've been working with this family for 8 weeks. The BSP is in place, school strategies are documented, parent training has happened. But the parent reports — at this week's review — that they're "running out of words" with their child. The same incidents keep happening. The parent feels like they're failing.

The intervention: hand them the Decoder. Ask them to read just one statement page (whichever feels closest to their child) tonight, and try one of the "what to say back" lines this week. *One page, one line, one week.*

What you're doing clinically: giving the exhausted parent a **scaffolding scripts** tool. The Decoder isn't introducing new strategy — it's giving language to strategy they already know but can't access under stress. When the prefrontal cortex is offline (theirs, not the child's), *scripts are more useful than principles.*

THE CLINICAL INSIGHT WORTH KNOWING

Parents in week 8+ of a behaviour support program often hit a wall not because the BSP is wrong but because **they've run out of ad-hoc language for the moments between strategies**. The Decoder doesn't replace the BSP — it provides verbal infrastructure for the moments the BSP doesn't cover.

Think of it as parent-side regulation co-pilot. Ten parents using it for two weeks generates ten data points on which "what to say back" lines actually land in real life — useful for refining your own clinical scripts.

A NOTE ON PARENT BURNOUT SPECIFICALLY

Parents of neurodivergent children show **elevated rates of burnout** consistent with caregiver-stress literature (Cousino & Hazen 2013; Padden & James 2017). Tools that reduce *cognitive load* in moments of high stress — providing language rather than requiring it to be generated — are functionally regulation supports for the parent. The Decoder is, in that sense, a co-regulation tool. *Frame it that way for the parent if helpful.*

USE CASE 3 · SCHOOL-SETTING USE · COUNSELLORS & LEARNING SUPPORT

SCENARIO

You're a school counsellor or learning support teacher. A child is referred with vague "behavioural concerns."

You have 30 minutes with the child once a week, possibly less. The referral is non-specific. Parents are inconsistently engaged. You need a **structured, low-friction way to build rapport and gather child voice** in a school setting that doesn't require formal assessment authority you may not have.

The intervention: use the worksheet alone (not the Decoder — the parent guide is for adults at home). Sit alongside the child. Read each statement aloud. Let them tick. Don't analyse, don't push, don't translate. *Just receive what they say.*

What you produce: a documented record of child voice, in the child's own marks and words, which can travel with the referral if escalation to allied health is needed. The "what helps" tickbox in particular generates **concrete classroom strategy data** that can be shared with classroom teachers without breaching confidentiality on the deeper conversation.

FOR SCHOOL STAFF SPECIFICALLY

You don't need parent consent to use this tool with a child in your professional scope — it's psychoeducation, not assessment, and it doesn't generate diagnostic information. *Verify against your school's specific policy*, but in most jurisdictions a school counsellor can use this resource as part of routine pastoral support without additional permissions. Treat the completed worksheet the same way you'd treat any pastoral note — confidential to the child, shareable in summary form when relevant, retained per your school's records policy.

FOR MULTI-DISCIPLINARY TEAMS

The completed worksheet works as a **handover document** when a child moves between school counsellor, external psychologist, and BSP. The child's voice, captured once, travels — reducing the burden on the child to repeat their experience to each new clinician. *This is a small but meaningful thing.* Children with multiple practitioners report fatigue at re-narrating; one document that travels with them prevents that.

FROM ONE PRACTITIONER TO ANOTHER

The work continues — and your input shapes it.

The Decoder + Worksheet pair is one piece of a wider body of work I'm developing for families and the practitioners who support them. **The clinical foundations are settled; the application keeps evolving** — and the practitioners using these resources with real children and real families are the people whose feedback changes what I make next.

If you've found something here useful — or something here questionable — *I'd genuinely like to hear about it*. Not as marketing data. As clinical conversation between practitioners trying to do this work better.

Two ways to stay connected, depending on where you sit.



FOR FELLOW PRACTITIONERS

Practitioner mailing list

Occasional emails from one BSP to others — clinical reflections, new resources as they're built, requests for input on tools in development. **No marketing, no pressure, unsubscribe any time.**

→ [REPLY TO MY EMAIL BELOW TO OPT IN](#)

FOR YOUR FAMILIES

DD platform · referral access

If a family on your caseload could benefit from the Daniel's Diaries platform, practitioner referral codes are available — they get the first month at half price.

→ [DANIELSDIARIES.COM.AU/PRACTITIONER](https://danielsdiaries.com.au/practitioner)

A GENUINE ASK

If you've used the Decoder or Worksheet with a family on your caseload — **even once** — I'd love to know how it went. Not as marketing feedback. As clinical feedback. Reply directly to my email below.

FROM ONE PRACTITIONER

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